

Illustration by SIDDHANT JUMDE

GLASSHOUSE

THE YOUNG LOOK

The BJP, it seems, is scouting for younger faces to include in Uttarakhand chief minister Pushkar Singh Dhami's cabinet. The 47-year-old CM has already done several rounds of Delhi to get the high command's clearance for four vacancies and a few other political appointments, but matters have not moved ahead. Now, with the Karnataka assembly election over, sources say the saffron party top leadership may finalise the new faces for the hill state. Speculation is rife that it may not just be a filling of vacancies but a full-blown cabinet reshuffle. The purported focus on 'youth', though, has left three 60-plus seniors in the Dhami cabinet a worried lot.

MINDING THE COPS



Bihar chief minister **Nitish Kumar** has never been a fan of surprise raids. But after 17 years on the job, perhaps he feels it's time to spring a surprise or two. His target? The state's police stations. What has apparently got the CM's goat are reports that many cops, including some senior ones, are working from home, communicating only via cellphones. Addressing a police function in Patna on May 4, Nitish even hinted at doing surprise checks at the *thanas* himself. The force is still mulling over his words; many feel it's just a warning and the CM may not take action. Or will he?

SIDE EFFECTS

Tamil Nadu BJP chief **K. Annamalai**'s strident anti-corruption campaign against the ruling DMK is showing signs of recoil on its Dravidian party ally, the AIADMK. A fallout of the joust has been DMK chief and CM M.K. Stalin turning up the vigilance heat against five ministers of the former E.K. Palaniswami-led AIADMK government. Sources in the state directorate of vigilance and anti-corruption say old cases are being revived and, in a bid to blunt the BJP's attacks, there may even be arrests. But even this could be to the BJP's gain: sources say it could bargain in the alliance for half of the state's 39 Lok Sabha seats in 2024.



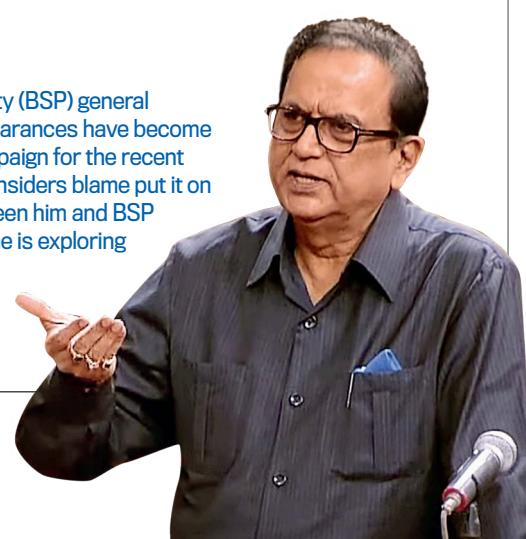


WHAT'S IN A COLOUR?

Colours in West Bengal have strong political overtones. Birbhum strongman and Trinamool Congress (TMC) leader **Anubrata Mondal**, now lodged in Tihar jail in a cow smuggling case, is known for wearing kurtas in varying shades of green, reflecting his party's colours. Last week, though, he sprang a surprise with an orange-coloured T-shirt in a social media post. The 63-year-old *neta* looked at peace, leaving the party bosses a tad worried. Was the change in colour a sign that Mondal was leaning saffronward? Have the central investigating agencies finally got to him?

Missing in Action

Once a party stalwart, Bahujan Samaj Party (BSP) general secretary **Satish Mishra**'s public appearances have become rare these days. He was also M.I.A. in the campaign for the recent local body polls in Uttar Pradesh. While party insiders blame put it on his poor health, all is apparently not well between him and BSP chief Mayawati. Sources close to Mishra say he is exploring "other options" after being sidelined in the wake of the disastrous assembly polls last year. The ruling BJP could be an option, but the saffron leadership is tight-lipped on this.



ANI

Kaushik Deka with Anilesh S. Mahajan, Amitabh Srivastava, Romita Datta, Amarnath K. Menon and Prashant Srivastava